Highflyer

At the age of 44, Erich Honecker could view his political career with a sense of achievement. ‘Enriched with new impressions and new insights,’ he returned to Germany in July 1956. ‘The study results were not bad,’ he recounted. ‘I finished with distinction. The time I studied in Moscow was altogether the finest in my life. My study there laid the decisive basis for my abilities later on – theoretical, political, economic and cultural.’1 As he moved closer to the inner circle of government, his annus mirabilis started with a change of demeanour, tidier social life and smarter image. Family life with Margot and daughter Sonja resumed at their spacious home on Majakowskiring in Pankow, a leafy cul-de-sac with century-old trees, pristine park and gildedage mansions. Prime Minister Otto Grotewohl lived next door, and around the corner, Walter and Lotte Ulbricht occupied a spacious villa. There was thick barbed wire fences around the grounds, a private park and tennis courts, from where Ulbricht could be heard grunting and shrieking during his daily practice.

While waiting for a full-time appointment, Honecker proved his usefulness by undertaking various jobs in the youth and sports movements. For starters, he led a team repairing storm damage at a mine, appeared at a gymnastics and sports festival, and took part in a ‘frank and open discussion’ about problems facing athletes and the future of the Olympic team.

Finally, he was appointed as the Central Committee secretary for security issues, giving him responsibility for the police and the state security service and the ‘National People’s Army’, which had been officially formed from the barracked People’s Police. One of his most important tasks was to muster recruits for so-called combat groups, a military-trained militia recruited from among the factory workers reporting directly to the SED leadership. As Heinz Lippman observed, Walter Ulbricht showed unlimited trust in Honecker by putting the state’s power apparatus in his hands: ‘The old Ulbricht-Honecker alliance was re-established after a one-year break at